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BJP campaign in the UP assembly election, but it was Shah who energised party cadre facing a tough battle in western UP in the background of the year-long farmers' protests. Yogi's cabinet and allocation of portfolios have the clear stamp of Shah.

In the run-up to the 2024 campaign, Shah has a lot on his plate. The ministry has still not drafted the subordinate rules governing the controversial CAA. Implementing it is a key poll promise of the BJP.

Shah is also keeping a watch on the 'political restructuring' of Jammu and Kashmir. In 2019, he tabled the legislation that abrogated Article 370 and reorganised the state into the Union territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh. Their administration comes under Shah's ministry. Subsequently, various laws in Jammu and Kashmir were harmonised with central ones—introduction of reservation for SCs/STs in state government services, for example. In early May, the J&K delimitation commission redrew the electoral boundaries of Jammu and Kashmir. Shah had kept an eye on the exercise. Criticised for its apparent tilt towards Hindu-dominated Jammu, Shah's task is to ensure peaceful elections and pave the return of statehood.

In the Northeast, under Shah, the home ministry is building consensus to withdraw the controversial Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act, 1958, or AFSPA. From April 1, AFSPA has been withdrawn from 15 police stations in seven districts of Nagaland. The ministry has also reduced the number of 'disturbed areas' under AFSPA in Nagaland, Assam and Manipur. The argument is that there has been considerable improvement in the law and order situation in the past eight years.

The task is now to bring other militant groups to the mainstream, and prevent incidents like the December ambush in Nagaland's Oting, when special forces killed six coal miners. Shah called it an incident of "mistaken identity" in Parliament and set up an SIT to investigate it. Under Shah, the ministry signed the Bodo Accord in 2020 to end a decades-long armed conflict. In September 2021, the Karbi Anglong Accord was signed with six militant groups. However, talks with the United Liberation Front of Asom (ULFA) and the National Socialist Council of Nagaland (I-M) are stalled. Officials in Shah's ministry claim that various development schemes reduced violence by Maoist groups by 54 per cent by 2020 in comparison to 2013.

With the 2024 general election now looming in the distance, all eyes will be on Shah. ■

CHALLENGES AHEAD

- **Framing rules in Citizenship (Amendment) Act to give citizenship to eligible refugees**
- **Crack down on recent challenges to Places of Worship Act**
- **Producing a draft of the uniform civil code**